

“In the Only House in the Whole World but Everyone Doing the Same” Co-designed Animation as a Method of Critical Enquiry to Explore HCI Considerations for Remote Eating Disorder Support.

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ABSTRACT

The COVID-19 pandemic accelerated the shift to remote support for Eating Disorders (ED), necessitating innovative integration of digital technologies. The RHED-C (Remote Healthcare for Eating Disorders throughout COVID-19) project builds upon insights from the pandemic to enhance future remote care. Co-designed animation was used as an ethnographic method, capturing experiences of support recipients. Creative workshops generated ideas and guided script/storyboard creation. Unique challenges to the application of animation were unveiled, emphasising careful visual representation of EDs, with a focus towards abstract representation and audio. The animation features voiceovers exclusively by individuals with lived experience. The implications of animation in this space are two-fold: Firstly, as an impactful way to disseminate findings beyond academia, raising awareness of remote support advantages and challenges. Secondly, as an inclusive approach capturing diverse forms of expression and individual preference. An accompanying documentary details the process, advocating for responsible application of co-designed animation in HCI research.

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1 INTRODUCTION

The COVID-19 pandemic exacerbated Eating Disorders/Distress (EDs) via abrupt routine changes, enforced isolation, limited access to safe foods, and public health messaging emphasising weight

loss and exercise [1-6]. Lockdown mandated a shift to remote support [7-9], providing a digital lifeline with increased service access, flexibility, and diverse support methods [10]; whilst potentially promoting help-seeking for those experiencing anxiety or stigma [11]. Demand for remote support is anticipated to continue [10]. However, reliant on innovative use of digital technology, remote support also faces challenges, both generic (e.g., digital self-efficacy/access) and nuanced (e.g., anxiety around self-view on video calls, privacy concerns around receiving remote support in the home, challenges to building effective therapeutic relationships, and increased opportunities to mask symptom severity [10, 12]). There is a noticeable dearth of research exploring the experiences of support recipients; we applied co-designed animation as an ethnographic method to explore this further - vividly capturing and sharing lived experiences. Ethnography, capturing lived experiences through individuals' self-expression [13-14] is particularly powerful when exploring sensitive subjects where ‘finding the right words’ is challenging. Co-design, integral to this process, involves collaborative work with listening at its core [15-18].

2 AIM

RHED-C (www.rhedc.uk) aims to learn from the pandemic to improve future remote support. This co-designed animation extends findings beyond academia, sharing experiences inclusively (with verbal and non-verbal expression) and providing an impactful, engaging way to raise awareness and prompt future considerations around support provision.

3 APPROACH & RESULTS

The documentary explores co-designing an animation with 12 recipients of remote ED support during the pandemic. The process involved: i. Creative arts workshops (in-person) using a pandemic timeline and RHED-C interview data to inspire ideas whilst promoting expressive use of marks and colour; ii. Script development based on thematic analysis of the workshops data [19]; iii. Storyboard creation with participant-led visuals and colours; iv. Recording participant voiceovers; and v. Creation of the final animation. Our iterative approach incorporated input from service users and an ED service provider throughout. The documentary reflects on this

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methodological process, highlighting nuanced challenges for ethnographical approaches within ED research, e.g., avoidance of visual representations of bodies for ethical reasons (to mitigate comparison and/or negative self-evaluation), and a focus on voices and abstract representation.

4 CONCLUSION

The application of co-designed animation provided an inclusive method to capture lived experiences, not limited to verbal or written expression. The result is an impactful, relatable video to raise awareness around the advantages and challenges of digital technologies for remote ED support, and to foster further conversation around how best to apply these in future. This accessible medium also helps promote dissemination beyond academic circles. The animation is accompanied by a short documentary detailing the step-by-step process and demonstrating how co-designed animation can be respectfully and responsibly employed as an ethnographic method by HCI researchers within sensitive subject areas. All materials from the project can be found on OSF (<https://osf.io/ucdkg/>).

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